

Nigerian Foreign Policy and the Issue of Image Building: A Critical Assessment of Muhammadu Buhari's Administration (2015-2019)

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Abstract:

Nigeria over decades have been battling with the dilemma of image building in the international environment as a result of terrorism, pervasive corruption, and leadership challenges that are bedeviling the country. These challenges among others have indeed negatively affected the positive image of the country amongst the comity of nations. This study, therefore, assessed Muhammad Buhari's Foreign Policy impacts on Nigeria's image building. The study relied on secondary data such as journals, magazines, articles, textbooks, and internet. The linkage Theory of James Rosenau (1969) was used in explaining the nature of Nigeria's foreign policy and the reason behind the intricacies surrounding the country's foreign policy. However, thematic and content analysis was used as a methodology that guides the research. The paper found that the foreign policy thrust of Muhammadu Buhari's administration is "Shuttle Diplomacy" which focused on foreign trips seeking the assistance of the international community to help Nigeria in its fight against Boko Haram insurgency, reviving the country's economic hardship, and tackle the pervasive corruption in the country. The paper also found that, even though Buhari's foreign policy did not achieve a persuading impact on the international community in terms of image-building and respect for the nation and Nigerians abroad, he however relatively resuscitated some of the nation's dilapidated image. However, the paper identified some social vices that are still downgrading the country's posture in the international environment. These include among others its high ranking on the corruption perception index, high rate of unemployment, violation of human rights, and insecurity. This study, therefore, recommends among other things that receptive efforts should be made to thwart the above-mentioned challenges.

KEYWORDS: Foreign Policy, Image building, Muhammadu Buhari, administration.



INTRODUCTION

A state with a decapitated image is difficult to advertise in the diplomatic market. A nation's ability to interact with other

nations is a reflection of its reception internationally, and evaluation of its level of civility in terms of behavioral conformity with international legal standards (Ajayi, 2005).

Therefore, a country's positive image needs to be formulated adequately to earn respect and relevancy around the globe. A good image guarantees a level of credibility and admiration of the international community. Conversely, a bad image and anguish of integrity and credibility dilemma deny a nation the necessary respect by other states and describes the concerned nation as a castaway state (Ajayi, 2005). Thus, the understanding of a country by members of the international community, how a country interacts with others, and particularly the character of its citizens at home and abroad can implicate a country's image. Hence, image building is a fundamental feature of a country's foreign policy. This explained the vital role of the global image of a country in pursuing a dynamic foreign policy. The image that a country attempts to create and project through its foreign policy must be guided by her national interest. To be clear, Morgenthau (1973) argues that "no nation can have a true guide as to what it needs to do in foreign policy without adopting national interest as an essential guide". If this is to be compared to the Nigerian system, for example, then the prevailing burden should be concentrated upon those parameters of Nigeria's core values that compose essential particles of her foreign policy. Therefore, it's imperative to contemplate: Do various Nigerian authorities consider the country's national interest at all, in the pursuit of foreign policy thrust to create a favorable image of the country Internationally? In this sense, foreign policy objectives and national interest must be systematically packaged and projected to achieve the desired aim. Akinboye, (2013) contends that Nigeria had indeed been squabbling with the challenges of image building for the past three decades. He identified the main issue obstructing the image to be corruption and mismanagement, and asserted that until the government demonstrates seriousness in fighting against corruption, Nigeria will not be treated seriously at the international level. He also pinpoints terrorism and riot to be other derivation of the image crisis in the country; alluding that until the fundamental domestic origins of Nigeria's image crisis have been addressed Nigeria's aspiration to be a regional powerful nation will remain a hallucination. This position taken by Akinboye, (2013), converges with the corruption perception index by Transparency International (2019) wherein it was recorded that Nigeria ranked 146 Out of 180 (Transparency International, 2019). This factor as revealed by Transparency International gives a perception to the world that Nigeria is indeed a highly corrupt country and when this is the case, the image of the country became negative to the rest of the world which in turn prevents the country from pursuing a robust and dynamic foreign policy. In this sense, there is no gainsaying that image building is of paramount importance for any nation that needs to pursue its national interest in the international environment. However, the question here is that did Nigeria's foreign policy under Muhammadu Buhari plays a significant role in restoring the country's battered image among the comity of nations? To answer these questions this paper, therefore, tends to examine Muhammad Buhari's foreign policy in rebuilding the Nigerian global image.

LITERATURE REVIEW

Nigeria's foreign policy records a diverse bag of achievements and failures, dynamism, and moderation. In the first republic, Nigeria's first Prime Minister, Sir Abubakar Tarawa Balewa, set

up the stages for Nigeria's foreign policy in 1960 when he outlined its major components. As summarized by Emikanolaiye, (2013) they encompass in no particular order: sovereign equality of states, respect for territorial integrity, good neighborhood, commitments to decolonization and eradication of racist minority rule from Africa, promotion of Pan-Africanism and African unity, promotion of the rights of the black man under colonial rule, respect for the principles of the united nation charter and non-alignment. However, with the invasion of the military into Nigerian politics from 1966-1979, the foreign policy of Nigeria took another dimension. Because of the rigid nature of the military, Nigeria's foreign policy tilted from conservative to assertive, this is clear if we look at the roles played by Nigeria in Africa and other parts of the world. To be clear, Odubajo (2017), stated that Nigeria's foreign policy was more assertive when the military took power as seeing in the leading roles played by Nigeria in the Organization of African unity, unanimous leadership of the West African region, the establishment of the Economic Community Of West African States in 1975, and the support for independence of many African countries. This era was described by many scholars as the golden era of Nigeria's foreign policy. The epoch of 1979 and 1984 suffered a radical departure from the prevailing pattern of previous foreign policy. The conservative nature of President Shehu Shagari conveyed Nigeria's foreign policy a low profile glance, like that of the period of Balewa's regime (Idahosa and Adebayo, 2017). However, the Buhari-Idiagbon regime made efforts at rebuilding the battered image of Nigeria after Shagari's tenure by steering in an anti-drug and anti-corruption policy to brighten the country's image (Folarin, 2013). During Babangida's regime, Nigeria documented a tremendous success in its interaction with other nations. This constitutes the re-election of Babangida to be the chairman of both ECOWAS and OAU and his struggle to restore peace between Mali and Burkina Faso. The standpoint of Nigeria in the comity of nations played a significant role in Joseph Garba been voted as president of the 44th session of the United Nations general assembly. Also during the period, prince Bola Ajibola was elected to the International Court of Justice to finish the unexpired term of late Dr. Taslim Elias, and Mr. Rilwanu Lukman was elected secretary-general of OPEC. Due to Babangida's regime, Nigeria also helped in governing the group ECOMOG to restore peace to war-torn Liberia and Sierra Leone. This era in the history of Nigeria's international engagement and foreign relations achieve overwhelming success (Ogidan.P. Damilola, 2012). The pinnacle of the deterioration in Nigeria's international image happened during the late General Abacha regime even though there are some scholars that debunk this claim. Abacha dispersed all democratic institutions, murdered many pro-democracy activists, and annihilated opponents and protesters. He had complete disregard for human liberties and the viewpoint of the international community (Folarin, 2013). Things got terrible with the execution of Ken Saro-Wiwa and his eight Ogoni kinsmen in November 1995, which put his regime at odds with the world, especially the United Nations, the Commonwealth, and the European Union (Onoja 2006). Indeed the regime is remarkable for the highest regime of sanctions imposed on Nigeria, and especially the members of the Nigerian military by

the international community. Following General Abacha's sudden demise in June 1998, General Abdulsalami Abubakar, his successor, initiated a transition strategy that resulted in the coming to power of President Olusegun Obasanjo on 29 May, 1999. Although the duration of the regime of Abdulsalami Abubakar was short, it was however significant in the history of Nigeria as he was able to persuade the international community of the honesty of his transition program, which overturns the negative tendency that Nigeria had had. As a result of this transition, Nigeria obtained great recognition among the International community and many sanctions were held up (Idahoza and Adebayo, 2017). With the successful Nigerian transition from the military dictatorship to democracy, Olusegun Obasanjo emerged as the country's democratic president between 1999-2007. The president has made numerous journeys overseas, which saw high profile foreign policy goals. President Olusegun Obasanjo inherited a nation with a decayed image and without credibility externally. He made concerted efforts to build the country's image and re-integrate Nigeria into the world. Consequently, Nigeria under his leadership led various international organizations like the G-7, the Economic Community of West Africa (ECOWAS), African Union (AU) (Boma-Lysa et al, 2015). This tally with the findings of Ujara and Obietan, (2017) that Obasanjo's administration succeeded relatively at rebuilding Nigerian image globally regardless of the internal challenges it experienced. Nigeria regime after regime, continues to rebuild its image internationally with vigour.

THEORETICAL FRAMEWORK

This study is anchored on the Linkage theory of James Rosenau (1969). The theory can explain adequately the nature of the Foreign policy of a state and the reason behind its ability or inability to pursue a robust and dynamic foreign policy and build a positive image in the external environment. Linkage theory was propounded by James Rosenau in 1969. The theory is simply explaining that the nature of the foreign policy of a state whether weak or strong and the ability or inability of a state to build a positive image in the international system or otherwise is the reflection of its domestic reality. The central argument of this theory is the reciprocal influence between domestic and international politics. As highlighted in this study, Nigeria is plagued with myriad challenges emanating from internal and external factors that may account for negative outcomes from foreign policy engagements. In this sense, Pada (2006), argues that the unification that exists between domestic and international factors is fully grasped in James Resenau's linkage theory. The theory ascertains that domestic factors determine and influence foreign policy pursued, thereby inducing a linkage between the national and international affairs of a state. Rosenau (1969), attempts to understand the relationship between domestic and foreign policy. He concentrates on the interconnectedness between the national political system and the advancement of foreign policy incidents and strategies.

The applicability of this theory to this study is that the theory attempts to ascertain the nexus between the domestic and external environments in Nigeria's foreign policy and the reinforced connection that prevails between domestic and international politics.

NIGERIA'S FOREIGN POLICY AND BUHARI ADMINISTRATION'S IMAGE-BUILDING INTERVENTION

President Muhammad Buhari appeared victorious in the March 28, 2015, presidential election having vanquished the incumbent Dr. Goodluck Jonathan of the People's Democratic Party (PDP). Almost 30 years after he was toppled from power, President Buhari a retired general who concealed democracy and politics at the break of the 21st century, became Nigeria's 15th political leader. Buhari has been interpreted by many people as the "masses comrade and the elites antagonist". He is feared by the elite over his inclined crackdown on corruption and mismanagement in government as well as indiscipline. He was believed to be the best choice of the masses and who the masses have an unequivocal assurance that he came to address their problems. Buhari's administration just like his forerunners adopted shuttle and economic diplomacy as a tool of foreign policy. The New President made a series of trips abroad where he visited four out of the five countries of the United Nations Security Council seeking their support in his fighting against terrorism particularly that of Boko Haram insurgency; fighting corruption; accelerating economic growth. This gave a new dimension to Nigerians foreign policy (Idahosa and Adebayo, 2017). Buhari also undertook an excursion to member-states of the Lake Chad Basin Commission in West Africa that are equally implicated by the activities of Boko Haram. He also visited France as a result of its interest in West Africa, and her close affinities with her former colonies. The visits were implied to seek cooperation and the assistance of the several governments in fighting the Boko Haram menace. In line with the government's eagerness, the Boko Haram panic issue accentuated prominently in the president's meeting with the US authorities on his official visit to America. In the final analysis, the contacts rendered with different governments yielded results in the mold of the Multinational Joint Task Force (MNJTF) (Assanvo et al. 2016). This effort made by Buhari seeking collaboration and cooperation of the international community in tackling Boko Haram insurgency had indeed yielded a positive result as many towns that were conquered by Boko Haram have been confiscated by the military and their persistent attacks on people have been drastically reduced as a result of the collaboration of other countries particularly neighboring one. This effort no doubt had relatively revived the positive image of Nigeria among the comity of nations. In his attempt to address Nigeria's economic challenges, the president has been visible on the global stage, trying to sell Nigeria as a haven of business chances to governments and companies around the world. Indeed, the president has left the space wide open without discrimination against any part of the world, either based on the doctrine of religion or color. As a result of this open mind, Buhari made several bilateral and multilateral visits to the United States of America, China, the United Arab Emirates, Germany, France, Saudi Arabia, and other hospitable nations in search of Foreign Direct Investment (FDI). In line with the nation's economic foreign policy thrust, the Buhari administration can be applauded for offers to attend G7 and G20 Summits, receptions in world capitals among others (Duke et al, 2017). This of course suggests that Buhari's shuttle diplomacy yielded a positive result as many nations agreed to cooperate with Nigeria and invest in its

Furthermore, the Chinese have agreed to establish a Transport University in Nigeria, build a Rail Wagon Assembly Plant, and also fund the construction of a new Deep Sea Port in Warri. This cooperation given by China to Nigeria of course suggested the integrity of Nigeria to China as they agreed to spend worth billions of Dollars in Nigeria. On the other hand, United States America-Nigeria relation is a positive one. Looking into the role that the U.S played in helping Nigeria to fight against Boko Haram, corruption, and revive its economy. According to Bello et al (2017), the interaction between both states under the Buhari administration commenced with high-level diplomatic discussions between Obama and Buhari which held at Oval on the 20th of July 2016. President Obama discloses that the United States will support the Nigerian government to tackle the increasing menaces of Boko Haram and counter violent extremism. The selling of military arms by Trump's administration to Nigeria to fight against Boko Haram which it denied its selling to Jonathan administration is another sign that shows a positive image of Nigeria among the comity of nations under Buhari led administration. To buttress this, Iroegbu, (2016) and Geonal, (2017), opined that, the Trump administration also demonstrated efforts to aid the Buhari administration in his fight against Boko Haram with the proposed sales of military equipment to Nigeria (12 Ember A-29 Super Tucano aircraft). Before Buhari came to power, Nigeria was blacklisted under President Jonathan by the U.S government, this led to declining of the requests for the purchase of military equipment (12 Ember A-29 Super Tucano aircraft). In a nutshell, the Buhari administration was able to restore the US-Nigeria relations which had deteriorated considerably during the previous administration. It renewed cooperation in Security and Anti-Corruption which led to repatriating recovered looted monies and assets stashed in the US. Furthermore, President Buhari also visited Saudi Arabia in October 28 – November 1, 2019, to discuss economic matters and to cooperate with each other to boost their economy. After President Buhari and Crown Prince Mohammed Ibn Salman discussion, they arrived at several things among which are: decided to set up a joint Saudi-Nigeria Strategic Council, to focus on economic growth and development, investments in oil and non-oil sectors, and security cooperation (Nigerian Project Initiative, 2019). This agreement between these countries of course will help Nigeria to reduce its youth's restiveness through working in the companies. Under the United Kingdom-Nigeria relationship, president Buhari made a series of trips to the United Kingdom. Following President Buhari's Participation in the London Anti-Corruption Summit in May 2016 where they have a fruitful discussion with the government of the UK and reach a number of agreements with the them. In August 2016 Buhari signed a Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) with the Government of UK on modalities for the return of Nigeria's stolen assets in their country; they also establish a Global Forum for Asset Recovery (GFAR), hosted by the governments of the US and UK in December 2017, and focusing on assisting Nigeria and three other countries to reclaim their stolen assets; Nigeria joined the Open Government Partnership (OGP) in 2016 and developed a National Action Plan, which is already being implemented. Furthermore, President Buhari's trips to Japan also yielded a positive result. The visit paid by president Buhari to Japan, yielded a positive outcome where they reached a number of

agreements among which are: Prime Minister Abe pledged a \$300,000 support for Nigeria's Defence College as well as 12 billion Yen for Nigeria's public health sector; On side-lines of TICAD IV (Nigerian Project Initiative, 2019). Furthermore, Nigeria and the European Union under President Buhari signed a €50 million Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) to support humanitarian and development efforts in Nigeria's North-East region; The cooperation agreement was signed by Nigeria's Foreign Affairs Minister, Geoffrey Onyeama, and EU Commissioner for International Cooperation and Development, Mr. Neven Mimica. This agreement would bring the total EU support to the country to €562million from 2014-2020. On the other hand, Russia-Nigerian relations cannot be overemphasized. When President Buhari reached a number of agreements with Russian government. These agreements include: Joint government-to-government Agreement for the Russians to return to Ajaokuta Steel Complex, to complete and operationalize it; Agreement and MoU signed between NNPC and the Russia's Lukoil, to upgrade their commercial relationship to a government-to-government backed partnership, and to work together in upstream operations and in revamping Nigeria's government-owned refineries; MoU on the revival of the rested joint venture between the NNPC and Russia's gas giant, GAZPROM; Agreement to renew lapsed Nigeria-Russia Military Technical Agreement. The agreement will elevate the procurement/sale of military hardware to a government-to-government level, eliminating middlemen and reducing cost will also provide a basis for training of military personnel, and refurbishment and renewal of infrastructure and equipment; Both countries agreed to kick-start the resolution of the protracted issue of the Aluminium Smelter Company of Nigeria, ALSCON, Ikot-Abasi, Akwa Ibom State (Nigerian Project Initiative, 2019). All these efforts made by Buhari and the cooperation given to him by the International community definitely are commendable and it showed how is committed to rebuilding Nigeria's image among the comity of nations. While the Buhari administration demonstrated elements of courage and commitment in deploying foreign policy to solve the various challenges at home, the government has equally been alive to its responsibility in the sub-region, in line with the underlying principles of the national interest. This is evidenced in the material and technical support provided for the following countries during their elections; Benin Republic, Burkina Faso, Chad, and Guinea Conakry. In 2016 the Nigerian government played a significant role as a leading member of ECOWAS to solve an impending political imbroglio in the Gambia. The group ensured that the recalcitrant former President Yahya Jammeh vacated office for the democratically elected President Adama Barrow. From all indications, Nigeria, Senegal, Liberia, and Ghana, under the auspices of ECOWAS, would have implemented a forceful removal of Yahya Jammeh from office (Freeman 2016)

CONCLUSION

From the foregoing discussion, it is known that Nigeria over the decades have been battling with image crises in the international community. However, Buhari's foreign policy have relatively rebuild Nigeria's positive image among the comity of nations looking at the cooperation and financial assistance he

received from international organizations and countries like USA, China, Saudi Arabia, Japan Russia European Union, and the World Health Organization (WHO), etc. Conclusively, it can be argued that under President Muhammadu Buhari, Nigeria-Sino relations have been taken to great heights with improvement in bilateral economic and diplomatic relations with other countries of the world. Arguably, we can conclude that Nigeria's global image is somewhat good among the comity of nations even though there are domestic challenges that are still confronting the country daily.

RECOMMENDATIONS

From the foregoing discussion, the following recommendations are provided:

I. Conscious attempts should be made to impede insecurity, crime, and corruption through invigorated institutions of governance and constructive surveillance anchored on resource provision and economical management. The ultimate effect of these on Nigeria's image cannot be overemphasized;

II. the anti-graft war is to be succeeded, the agencies charged with ensuring morality and responsibility in governance should be made autonomous. This can be done by assuring that the commissions generate and control their funds so that they do not depend on the federal government. Through this, they will determine their fate on how far they are willing to go to prosecute any case. This will reveal to the world that Nigeria is serious and ready to break its unenviable romance with corruption;

III. Nigerian government should put decisive effort and be proactive on everything that will help her to project a positive image in the world.

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